YEAR 7 DRAMA

Casual Cover Lesson 1 — What Is Drama?

Learning Intention

We are learning what Drama is and how students work as dramatic practitioners.

Success Criteria

- I can explain Drama in simple terms.
- I can identify Making, Performing and Appreciating.
- I can use basic Drama vocabulary correctly.
- I can explain how Drama communicates meaning to an audience.

Instructions

1. Complete the Do Now independently.
2. Read the information carefully. Everything you need is included.
3. Complete each activity in order and use full sentences where required.
4. This lesson can be completed at your desk. You are not required to perform.
5. If you finish early, complete the Extension Task.

Do Now — What Do You Already Know?

1. When you hear the word DRAMA, what do you think of? Write three ideas.

_____

_____

2. Name one place where you might see acting or performance.

_____

_____

3. What do you think an actor needs to do to make an audience believe in a character?

_____

_____

Part A — Drama: The Basics

Drama is a creative art form in which people explore and communicate ideas, stories, roles, characters and situations. Drama can represent real or imagined experiences. A dramatic work is shaped so that meaning can be communicated to an audience.

In the NSW Drama 7–10 syllabus, students learn through three connected practices: Making, Performing and Appreciating.

MAKING

Creating and shaping dramatic work. Students may generate ideas, explore roles and situations, improvise, devise scenes, interpret scripts and make choices about how a dramatic work will communicate meaning.

PERFORMING

Staging and presenting dramatic work. Performers use voice and movement, along with dramatic and production elements, to communicate meaning and engage an audience.

APPRECIATING

Thinking about and responding to drama. Students describe, explain and make informed judgements about their own work and the work of others. Appreciating helps students understand how creative choices affect an audience.

Part B — First Drama Vocabulary

Role: The part or function a performer takes within a dramatic situation.

Character: A person represented in a dramatic work. A character can be developed through choices about voice, movement, relationships, objectives and behaviour.

Audience: The people who experience a dramatic performance or work.

Dramatic meaning: The ideas, feelings, images and stories communicated to an audience.

Improvisation: Spontaneous performance used to explore or create drama.

Ensemble: A group of people who perform together to create a unified work.

Part C — Comprehension

1. What can Drama explore and communicate?

_____

2. What are the three connected practices in Drama?

_____

3. What does Making involve?

_____

_____

4. What does Performing involve?

_____

_____

5. What does Appreciating involve?

_____

_____

6. What is a role?

_____

7. What is a character?

_____

8. What is an audience?

_____

9. What does improvisation mean?

_____

10. What is an ensemble?

_____

11. Why might Appreciating help someone become better at Drama?

_____

_____

Part D — Making, Performing or Appreciating?

_____ — Planning what happens in a scene.

_____ — Using your voice to communicate a character.

_____ — Explaining why a performance choice was effective.

_____ — Improvising ideas for a new scene.

_____ — Presenting a scene to an audience.

_____ — Reflecting on how tension was created.

Part E — Vocabulary Match

Match: ROLE | CHARACTER | AUDIENCE | IMPROVISATION | ENSEMBLE | DRAMATIC MEANING

_____ — A group that performs together.

_____ — The people experiencing the performance.

_____ — A person represented in a dramatic work.

_____ — Spontaneous performance used to explore or create drama.

_____ — The part or function taken in a dramatic situation.

_____ — Ideas, feelings, images and stories communicated to an audience.

Part F — Apply Your Knowledge

Imagine a scene in which a new student enters the wrong classroom on their first day.

1. Who could the characters be?

_____

_____

2. What could the situation be?

_____

_____

3. What feeling or idea might the audience understand?

_____

_____

4. Give one choice a performer could make with their voice.

_____

_____

5. Give one choice a performer could make with their movement.

_____

_____

Part G — Short Response

Explain the difference between Making, Performing and Appreciating Drama. Give one example of each.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Extension — Your First Scene Idea

Create a simple idea for a dramatic scene. Include: setting, 2–3 characters, situation/problem, and what you want the audience to understand or feel.

Setting: _____

_____

Characters: _____

_____

Situation/problem: _____

_____

Audience should understand/feel:_____

_____

YEAR 7 DRAMA

Creating a Character

Learning Intention

We are learning how performers use voice and movement to communicate a character.

Success Criteria

- I can identify choices that help create a character.
- I can explain how voice and movement communicate meaning.
- I can distinguish a character from the actor performing the role.
- I can plan a character without needing to perform.

Instructions

1. Complete the Do Now independently.
2. Read the information carefully. Everything you need is included.
3. Complete each activity in order and use full sentences where required.
4. This lesson can be completed at your desk. You are not required to perform.
5. If you finish early, complete the Extension Task.

Do Now — Reading People

1. List THREE things you can notice about the way a person speaks.

_____

_____

2. List THREE things you can notice about the way a person moves.

_____

_____

3. Without using dialogue, how could a performer show that a character is nervous?

_____

_____

Part A — Actor, Role and Character

In Drama, the performer and the character are not the same person. A performer makes deliberate choices to represent a role or character. These choices help an audience understand who the character is, what they are feeling and what may be happening in the scene.

The NSW Drama syllabus identifies voice and movement as central to performance. Performers refine voice and movement using dynamics, clarity, energy and expression.

Voice

A performer can make choices about volume, pace, pitch, pause, tone and emphasis. Clear speech helps an audience understand words, while expression can communicate feelings and attitudes.

Movement

A performer can use posture, gesture, facial expression, stillness, movement and use of space. Movement can suggest a character's age, confidence, mood, relationships and intentions.

Consistency

Character choices should usually make sense together. For example, a confident character might use an upright posture, purposeful movement and a clear voice. A performer can deliberately break expectations, but choices should still help communicate meaning.

Part B — Comprehension

1. Why are the performer and character not the same person?

_____

_____

2. What two main performance areas are identified in the reading?

_____

_____

3. Name FIVE choices a performer can make with their voice.

_____

_____

4. Name FIVE choices connected with movement.

_____

_____

5. What can clear speech help an audience do?

_____

_____

6. How can facial expression help communicate character?

_____

_____

7. What does consistency mean when creating a character?

_____

_____

8. Why should performance choices make sense together?

_____

_____

Part C — What Does the Choice Suggest?

Performance choice: A character speaks very quietly and keeps looking towards the door.
What might this communicate to an audience?

_____

_____

Performance choice: A character stands upright, looks directly at others and speaks clearly.
What might this communicate to an audience?

_____

_____

Performance choice: A character rushes into the space, breathes quickly and speaks at a fast pace.
What might this communicate to an audience?

_____

_____

Performance choice: A character pauses for a long time before answering a simple question.
What might this communicate to an audience?

_____

_____

Performance choice: A character folds their arms and turns their body away from another character.
What might this communicate to an audience?

_____

_____

Part D — Build a Character

Create a fictional character suitable for a school Drama activity. Keep the idea simple and realistic.

Character name: _____

Age: _____

Where are they? _____

What do they want in the scene?

_____

One personality trait: _____

Posture: _____

Facial expression: _____

Typical gesture: _____

Voice volume: _____

Voice pace: _____

Voice tone: _____

Part E — Character in a Situation

Your character has just realised they have brought the wrong bag to school.

1. What would the character do first?

_____

_____

2. What facial expression would they use?

_____

_____

3. How would their voice change?

_____

_____

4. How would they move?

_____

_____

5. What should the audience understand about the character?

_____

_____

Part F — Short Response

Explain how voice AND movement can help a performer communicate a character to an audience. Use at least two specific examples.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Extension — Two Different Characters

Show how TWO different characters could react to the same event: being told they must give a speech in front of the whole year group.

Character A reaction:

_____

_____

Voice choices:

_____

_____

Movement choices:

_____

_____

Character B reaction:

_____

_____

Voice choices:

_____

_____

Movement choices:

_____

_____

YEAR 7 DRAMA

Introducing the Elements of Drama

Learning Intention

We are learning how some basic elements of drama help shape a scene.

Success Criteria

- I can identify role, character, situation, focus, tension, space and atmosphere.
- I can recognise these elements in simple examples.
- I can explain how changing an element can change a scene.
- I can apply the elements when planning drama.

Instructions

1. Complete the Do Now independently.
2. Read the information carefully. Everything you need is included.
3. Complete each activity in order and use full sentences where required.
4. This lesson can be completed at your desk. You are not required to perform.
5. If you finish early, complete the Extension Task.

Do Now — What Makes a Scene Interesting?

Imagine a scene where two students discover a locked box under a classroom desk.

1. What questions would the audience want answered?

_____

_____

2. What could make this situation tense?

_____

_____

3. Where could the performers stand to make the box seem important?

_____

_____

Part A — What Are Dramatic Elements?

Dramatic elements are tools used to shape dramatic meaning and audience engagement. The NSW syllabus includes thirteen elements of drama. As beginners, this lesson focuses on seven that are useful when first creating and understanding scenes.

Role

The part or function taken within a dramatic situation.

Character

A person represented in a dramatic work.

Situation

The circumstances or problem happening in the drama: who is involved, where they are and what is occurring.

Focus

What the audience's attention is directed towards or what is most important in a moment.

Tension

A sense of anticipation, pressure, uncertainty or conflict that keeps an audience interested in what may happen.

Space

How the performance area is used, including where performers or objects are placed and the distance between them.

Atmosphere

The mood or feeling created in a dramatic moment or work.

Other elements of drama named in the NSW syllabus are time, structure, language, moment, belief and symbol. You will encounter these as you develop your Drama skills.

Part B — Comprehension

1. What are dramatic elements used to shape?

_____

_____

2. How many elements of drama are identified in the NSW syllabus?

_____

_____

3. What is a situation?

_____

_____

4. What does focus direct?

_____

_____

5. What is tension?

_____

_____

6. What does space refer to in Drama?

_____

_____

7. What is atmosphere?

_____

_____

8. Name the six other elements listed at the end of Part A.

_____

_____

Part C — Name the Element

_____ — The audience's attention is directed towards a mysterious letter on the table.

_____ — Two characters stand at opposite sides of the room after an argument.

_____ — The scene feels cheerful and relaxed.

_____ — A student is waiting outside the principal's office after being called from class.

_____ — The audience knows someone is approaching, but the character on stage does not.

_____ — A performer represents the school captain.

_____ — The school captain is developed as confident in public but worried when alone.

Part D — One Situation, Different Choices

Base situation: Two friends are waiting for the results of an important competition.

1. What could be the FOCUS of the scene?

_____

_____

2. How could TENSION be created?

_____

_____

3. How could SPACE show that the friends are uncomfortable with each other?

_____

_____

4. Describe an anxious ATMOSPHERE.

_____

_____

5. Describe a completely different atmosphere that could be created using the same situation.

_____

_____

Part E — Scene Detective

Read this invented practice scenario:

Mia waits alone beside a closed door. She checks the clock repeatedly. When Noah arrives, Mia quickly hides a folded piece of paper behind her back. Noah notices the movement but says nothing. Both characters look towards the door when footsteps are heard outside.

1. What is the situation?

_____

_____

2. What could the folded paper become the focus of?

_____

_____

3. Identify TWO details that create tension.

_____

_____

4. How is space used in the scenario?

_____

_____

5. Suggest an atmosphere and explain which detail creates it.

Part F — Short Response

Choose TWO elements of drama and explain how they could be used to make a simple scene more engaging for an audience.

Extension — Change One Element

Return to the Mia and Noah scenario. Change ONE element of drama so the scene feels completely different. Identify the element, describe your change and explain its effect on the audience.

YEAR 7 DRAMA

From an Idea to a Scene

Learning Intention

We are learning how dramatic practitioners can develop a simple idea into a clear scene for an audience.

Success Criteria

- I can identify a clear situation and focus.
- I can organise a scene using a simple structure.
- I can plan character, tension, space and atmosphere.
- I can explain how creative choices communicate meaning.

Instructions

1. Complete the Do Now independently.
2. Read the information carefully. Everything you need is included.
3. Complete each activity in order and use full sentences where required.
4. This lesson can be completed at your desk. You are not required to perform.
5. If you finish early, complete the Extension Task.

Do Now — Building a Story

Put these basic story stages in a sensible order by numbering them 1–4.

_____ A problem becomes more difficult.

_____ The audience learns who and where the characters are.

_____ The scene reaches an important moment.

_____ The characters respond to what has happened.

Why does an audience need to understand what is happening in a scene?

_____

_____

_____

Part A — Starting with a Situation

A scene does not need a complicated story. A clear dramatic situation gives performers something to explore. A useful starting point answers: Who is involved? Where are they? What is happening? What does each character want?

Dramatic practitioners make choices to shape meaning. They might decide what the audience should focus on, where performers will be positioned, how tension will build, what atmosphere will be created and how voice and movement will communicate the characters.

Part B — Giving a Scene Structure

Structure is one of the elements of drama. For a beginner scene, it can help to organise dramatic action into a simple sequence:

1. Establish

Introduce the characters, place and situation so the audience can understand what is happening.

2. Develop

Something changes or a problem becomes more complicated. Characters respond and the audience learns more.

3. Important moment

The scene reaches a moment of strong focus, tension, discovery, decision or change.

4. End

The scene finishes at a deliberate point. The problem may be solved, partly solved or deliberately left unresolved.

Part C — Performance and Production Choices

Performers communicate using voice and movement. Drama can also use elements of production: set, costume, lighting, props, sound and technologies. A beginner scene does not need elaborate production. Even one carefully chosen prop or a simple use of space can help establish a situation or direct the audience's attention.

Part D — Comprehension

1. What four questions can help establish a dramatic situation?

_____

_____

2. Why does a scene not need a complicated story?

_____

_____

3. What happens during the Establish stage?

_____

_____

4. What happens during the Develop stage?

_____

_____

5. What might happen at the important moment?

_____

_____

6. Does a scene's problem always need to be completely solved? Explain.

_____

_____

7. What two main tools do performers use to communicate?

_____

_____

8. List the six elements of production identified in Part C.

_____

_____

9. Why might one carefully chosen prop be more useful than many random props?

_____

_____

Part E — Put the Scene in Order

Number these events from 1–4.

_____ The students open the envelope and stare at what is inside.

_____ Two students enter an empty classroom looking for a missing workbook.

_____ They hear someone trying to open the locked classroom door.

_____ They discover an envelope labelled with one student's name under a desk.

Which event would probably create the strongest moment of focus? Explain.

_____

_____

_____

Part F — Plan a Scene

Scenario: Two students arrive early for an excursion and realise everyone else has disappeared.

Characters: _____

Setting: _____

Situation: _____

What Character 1 wants: _____

What Character 2 wants: _____

Main focus: _____

How tension will be created:

_____

How space will be used: _____

Atmosphere: _____

One useful prop: _____

Part G — Structure Your Scene

ESTABLISH — What does the audience first see and learn?

_____

_____

_____

DEVELOP — What changes or makes the problem harder?

IMPORTANT MOMENT — What discovery, decision or change occurs?

END — Where will you deliberately finish the scene?

Part H — Performance Choices

1. Describe one voice choice for Character 1 and explain what it communicates.

2. Describe one movement choice for Character 2 and explain what it communicates.

3. What should the audience understand or feel by the end of the scene?

Extension — Appreciating Your Plan

Imagine your planned scene has been performed. Identify TWO creative choices that would be important to its success and explain how each would shape the audience's experience.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____